

A measure before Japan

India's Continental Tour Silver meet in Bhubaneswar offered a **timely test** before the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, with Abinaya Rajarajan's 11.34s the standout performance.

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For 11.34 seconds, Abinaya Rajarajan (**below**) was a blur on Kalinga Stadium's blue straight. The pause after the finish seemed longer. She turned towards the clock and let six months of emotion escape. Tears arrived first. Then came Cristiano Ronaldo's 'Siuuu', and the crowd joined in, capturing the defining moment of India's first World Athletics Continental Tour Silver meet.

School and college children filled the packed stands, alongside athletes from the Odisha Reliance High Performance Centre. A day of drizzle had given way to a rain-free but humid evening; when Abinaya asked for a response, Kalinga answered.

Running into a 0.1 m/s headwind, Abinaya cut 0.19 seconds off Nipam Chauhan's Indian Under-20 100m record of 11.53 to reclaim her 11.54 mark. Only senior record-holder Dutee Chand (11.17) and Rachita Mistry (11.26) have run faster among Indian women.

Those preceding months gave the

moment extra weight. Abinaya hit the crash pads after the 60m at February's Asian Indoor Championships, injuring her ACL, meniscus and patella. She spent three months on the sidelines. She lost her U-20 record, then missed an individual Asian Games place but made the 4x100m relay pool.

June's Inter-State Championships were AFI's sole selection trial, so the Silver meet could not reopen the team. The irony was that 11.34 was 0.20 seconds faster than the individual standard for the women's

